

In early March, new parliamentary elections still did not yield a Nazi majority. Despite the virtual silencing of opposition parties, the Nazis won only 43.9 percent of the popular vote. A parliamentary coalition headed by the Nazis was, however, ready to use democratic means to end democratic governance. The Enabling Act, passed in March, was opposed only by the Social Democrats; the Communist party had been banned in early March. Hitler's cabinet could now assume complete responsibility for introducing new laws. One of its first laws, passed in July, eliminated all political parties except the NSDAP. Hitler's continued commitment to proceeding by legal means assuaged the fears of many middle-class Germans that the Nazis would operate outside the law, making it possible for them to look past the regime's consistent reliance on extra-legal violence to maintain its authority, crush opponents, and quiet dissent.

LIFE IN NAZI GERMANY

Nazi policies were backed by force — the police and the Gestapo (Geheime Staatspolizei, or state secret police). But the state did not have to coerce most Germans to accept the end of parliamentary democracy and the institution of one-party authoritarian rule. Millions of Germans welcomed the suppression of the political left, the destruction of the trade union movement, the end of parliamentary wrangling, and Hitler's promise that he would lead Germany into a brighter future. They also welcomed signs of the return of economic prosperity and programs that promised to even out social inequality and create new opportunities for workers (Document 12). Those who still required encouragement and instruction to embrace Nazi rule needed to look no further than the Ministry for Popular Enlightenment and Propaganda, headed by Joseph Goebbels, whose responsibilities included oversight of many forms of cultural production and the media. For the Nazis, propaganda did not manipulate; rather, it educated and illuminated (Document 13). The propagandistic message of power, infallibility, confidence, and authority was also clearly conveyed at the carefully orchestrated annual Nazi party congresses in the city of Nuremberg (Document 14).

Hitler went to great lengths to reassure important organizations, especially the Catholic Church and the military, that he would not challenge their authority (Document 15). Plans to bring Protestant Christianity into a unified structure headed by an enthusiastic

supporter of Hitler, however, ran into opposition from many Protestant clerics. Although they insisted on religious autonomy from the Nazi state (Document 16), they stopped far short of openly challenging the regime's political authority. The main targets of Nazi political violence in the spring and summer of 1933 were trade unionists, Social Democrats, and Communists, all lumped together by Hitler and his followers as "Marxists" and "November criminals," the groups the Nazis held responsible for Germany's woes. The Nazis also attacked other highly visible symbols of Weimar modernity, such as movements for sexual reform. In early May, a student organization torched the library of Magnus Hirschfeld's Institute for Sexual Science in Berlin. Hirschfeld, well known as a leading champion of sexual reform and homosexual rights, was also a Jew (see Document 2). The Nazis could hate him for more than one reason. Hirschfeld was outside Germany at the time, but the crowd burned as many as ten thousand of the books in his library. This was only one of countless events nationwide in which books considered "un-German" were publicly put to the torch.

Through a process called "coordination," the Nazis brought cultural institutions, sports clubs, professional organizations, and the press into line with Nazi principles, purging those who did not meet the racial, political, sexual, and religious criteria of the Nazi state. Thousands of political activists, artists, scientists, composers, musicians, writers, and other opponents of the Nazis, as well as many German Jews, left the country, resulting in a major loss of intellectual talent. Among those who fled were scientist Albert Einstein, novelist Thomas Mann, philosopher Hannah Arendt, and Austrian-born film director Fritz Lang.

The regime's attempts to promote a National Socialist aesthetic, free of Jewish influence and the experimental tendencies of Weimar, were exemplified by its attitude toward artistic production. For the Nazis, what Weimar had fostered was "degenerate art," a very broad label that included the work of artists on the political left, such as Otto Dix and George Grosz, whose depictions of disabled veterans of World War I carried a strong pacifist and antiwar message, but also Franz Marc, whose landscapes featured whimsical cows, excoriated because they were unrealistic fantasies that no German farmer could possibly recognize. The work of many non-German artists, including Paul Klee, Marc Chagall, and Wassily Kandinsky — all very much at home on the Weimar cultural scene — also was banned. In place of an abstract art that allegedly misrepresented reality and created only confusion, the Nazis substituted a realist "German art" that featured muscular male

nudes, a militarized masculinity often conveyed by swords and other military regalia, big-breasted blond women ready to suckle a newborn (a vision of femininity that was firmly tied to women's maternal responsibilities), noble peasants, solemn cows, and Hitler in every imaginable pose (Document 17). For the Nazis, music could also be degenerate. Perhaps not surprisingly, they outlawed American jazz, which they claimed was the pernicious product of one racially inferior group, African Americans, promoted by another, Jews (Document 18). But they also forbade the performance of the music of much-loved classical composers such as Felix Mendelssohn. For the Nazis, Mendelssohn's baptism as a Christian did not alter his racial classification as a Jew. Many artists, composers, and musicians left Germany, and the cultural impoverishment of the Third Reich translated into the incalculable cultural enrichment of Britain, the United States, and many other countries in the world.

Those who remained in Germany and resisted the regime risked being sent to concentration camps, although Hitler reassuringly told the public that these facilities were committed only to reeducation and rehabilitation (Document 19). But, in fact, prisoners found themselves under the arbitrary control of the Nazi police state (Document 20). Before 1938, the camps interred relatively few Jews. Instead, those incarcerated included mainly political and religious opponents, such as Jehovah's Witnesses, who rejected all state authority; so-called asocials—prostitutes, vagrants, drunks, or those whom the Nazis deemed not fit for the “national community”; and male homosexuals, whose sexuality made them both criminals and outsiders in a society that celebrated heterosexual families with many children. Although the camps provided a potent warning of what might await any opponent of the regime, many Germans agreed that the earliest inmates deserved their fate and were best kept out of the way.

Hitler also made it clear that he would brook no opposition from within the ranks of the Nazi faithful. After 1933, some enthusiastic Nazis had been disappointed to see that Hitler had not made a clean break with the past. They still hoped for the “second revolution,” in which the Nazis would not compromise with conservative elites. In particular, Ernst Röhm, an early backer of Hitler who headed the SA, felt that the state and the military had not ensured that all political and military leaders were loyal Nazis. Röhm not only wanted to see committed Nazis and storm troopers take over military and state offices, however. He also was critical of the conservative moral order that

condemned his homosexual inclinations. On the night of June 30, 1934, following Hitler's orders, units of the Schutzstaffel (SS, Protection Squad) put an end to Röhm's aspirations, killing him and several other opponents of the regime. The Night of Long Knives, as it became known, made clear to Germans that Hitler would not hesitate to move against his followers, and his actions met with broad popular support from those who were critical of Röhm on both political and moral grounds (Document 21).

At the annual party rally the following fall, Hitler assured the party faithful that he would not forget those who had brought him to power, and in a highly orchestrated spectacle, he affirmed the unity of the Nazi movement. But the Röhm assassination made clear that the power of the SA would be carefully circumscribed even as the authority of the SS steadily expanded. Although the SS had its origins as a special group charged with protecting Hitler, by the mid-1930s, under Heinrich Himmler, who became head of the SS and controlled the Gestapo, it attained independent status and assumed more and more police powers, including responsibility for running the concentration camps and implementing Nazi racial policy.

Although Hitler relied heavily on force and terror to eliminate opposition, the Third Reich was also founded on “positive” conceptions of the unity and equality of all those who could claim “Aryan” status, defining what historians Michael Burleigh and Wolfgang Ippermann have called the “racial state.”⁵ “Aryan” had originally been used in the nineteenth century to describe speakers of Germanic languages. For the Nazis, it became synonymous with a German whose family history revealed no traces of racial mixing and who was thus assumed to be racially superior. Women played a vital role in the Aryan race because they knew best “what is necessary so that a race does not die out” (Document 22). Promoting healthy Aryan families was a central part of Nazi domestic policy (Document 23). In 1933, the Nazi state adopted a law that granted loans to young married couples, if the wife agreed to leave wage work and devote herself exclusively to motherhood. Intensifying prosecution of violations of Paragraph 218 of the criminal code, which outlawed abortion, was another part of this radically pronatalist regime. The Nazis were also intent on organizing boys and girls at a young age in order to indoctrinate them in the Nazi worldview. Accompanied by a constant drumbeat of Nazi ideology, the Hitler Youth (Hitler Jugend) and the League of German Girls (Bund deutscher Mädel) provided young people with all sorts of activities (Document 24). The

overwhelming majority of German young people were happy to wear the swastika and raise their arms in the Hitler salute.

Although the science behind the Nazi racial theory was highly suspect and constantly subject to revision, Nazi conceptions of race divided outsiders and insiders. Heading the roll call of outsiders were Jews, but they were not the only ones who were driven from the "national community." The Nazis also viewed all people of African descent as inferior. Reality sometimes powerfully challenged ideology and racial doctrine. In 1936, the Olympic Games in Berlin gave the Nazis an opportunity to welcome the world to the new Germany, putting on display the evidence of Aryan racial superiority. Much to their dismay, Jesse Owens, an African American, walked away with four gold medals (Document 25). Still, if Owens could go home with the gold, for all Afro-Germans who were primarily the children of German women and black French colonial troops who had been recruited during World War I and ended up occupying parts of Germany after the war, no such exit route existed. In 1937, the Nazis ordered that all children of these postwar unions should be sterilized.

Joining Jews and Afro-Germans on the list of outsiders were Gypsies (Sinti and Roma; Document 29). Also highly suspect were individuals judged to have serious mental illnesses or to be bearers of hereditary diseases; more than 360,000 of them were sterilized (Document 26). And those whose mental or physical disabilities or terminal illnesses made their lives "worthless," according to the Nazis, were subject to murder. In a famous dramatic film from 1941, *Ich klage an* (*I Accuse*), director Wolfgang Liebeneiner made the case for "euthanasia" and also provided a stunning example of the Nazis' use of the immensely popular film medium to convey their views (Document 27). The euthanasia campaign claimed some 267,000 lives in Germany and Nazi-occupied Europe. Homosexual men also were persecuted. Although Paragraph 175 of the criminal code, which outlawed same-sex activity between men, had been on the books since 1871, provisions of the law were dramatically expanded in 1935 (Document 28). Between 1933 and 1945, the Nazis prosecuted about 50,000 homosexual men, two-thirds of whom received jail sentences. Lesbians were excluded from criminal prosecution because, according to Nazi legal experts, lesbians were not as aggressive and predatory as male homosexuals and because, at least potentially, lesbians could become mothers and contribute to the goal of an ever-expanding racially fit population. In a society that placed such a high priority on motherhood, however, lesbians could hardly be open about their sexual orientation.

Of all the Third Reich's perceived enemies, none were more threatening and dangerous to Hitler than Jews. From the party's early history, Hitler made clear that anti-Semitism was at the core of his worldview. Although the Nazi party downplayed attacks on Jews in its electoral propaganda before 1933, once in power Hitler pursued both legal means and extra-legal violence to push German Jews to the margins of society—the "social death" that preceded the Nazi plan to exterminate all Jews.⁶ The Nazis launched a constant anti-Semitic barrage in popular magazines, radio broadcasts, newspapers, posters, and primers used to teach young Germans reading, writing, and arithmetic. One popular, highly melodramatic film from 1940, *Jud Süß* (*The Jew Süß*), directed by Veit Harlan, depicted eighteenth-century Jews as attempting to integrate themselves into German society in order to corrupt and undermine it. The underlying message was that Jews had always been a threat to Germans.

Anti-Semitism also became part of Germany's official legal policy. The Law for the Protection of German Blood and German Honor and the Reich Citizenship Law, collectively called the Nuremberg Laws because they were proclaimed at the annual Nazi party conference held in that city in September 1935, defined the status of German Jews, robbed them of their citizenship, criminalized their sexual relations with persons of "German or racially related blood," and restricted their activities in ways that anticipated the accelerating erosion of their rights in the years that followed (Document 30). Memoirs written by German Jewish survivors yield rich insights into the daily tyranny that they encountered during the 1930s (Documents 31 and 32).

German Jews responded by creating cultural, social welfare, and educational institutions to replace those to which they no longer had access. Many also chose emigration, but leaving Germany was not easy. Tight immigration policies in countries such as Britain and the United States limited the places to which German Jews could flee. Liquidating property in an economic climate where Aryans offered Jews less and less for their belongings made it difficult to amass the necessary capital to emigrate. Many German Jews also were tied to Germany by strong bonds of language and culture. And because Hitler was never explicit about his intentions, it was possible for some German Jews to believe that things would get no worse.

On the night of November 9, 1938, the SA obliterated any hopes that the regime's anti-Semitic trajectory would be halted or reversed (Document 33). Responding to the news that a seventeen-year-old Polish Jew had assassinated Ernst vom Rath, a foreign service officer

at the German embassy in Paris, the SA used massive force against Jews across Germany, and their acts were sanctioned by the Nazi leadership. Because the windows of so many Jewish businesses and synagogues were shattered, leaving the streets of German and Austrian cities littered with shards of glass, the event became known as Kristallnacht, or the "Night of Broken Glass." For the first time, German Jews were arrested in large numbers, and the barrage of anti-Semitic legislation that followed was a clear indication that there was no longer any place for Jews in Germany. In January 1939, all German Jewish men were required to add "Israel" to their legal names. The counterpart for women was "Sara." Jews were now publicly placed even further outside the Nazis' national community. Kristallnacht triggered a wave of German Jewish emigration, but the state's move to seize Jewish assets, combined with the continued resistance of many nations to accept Jewish immigrants, meant that for some there was no option but to remain in Germany and face a terrifying future. Historians estimate that between 270,000 and 300,000 Jews, about three-fifths of the 1933 population, were ultimately able to leave Germany, but the Nazis would later apprehend about 30,000 of them during World War II in other parts of Europe.

After the Nazi takeover, German society was increasingly treacherous for those excluded from the national community. But by the late 1930s the future looked bright for insiders who could document a racially acceptable genealogy and who supported the state that governed them. Most Germans were pleased with what the Führer had accomplished, and Joseph Goebbels could point to a thriving economy approaching full employment in his propagandistic attempts to surround Hitler with a myth of infallibility.⁷

GERMANY GOES TO WAR

Most Germans enthusiastically applauded the signs of the reassertion of Germany's position as a major political power in Europe and Hitler's determined efforts to reverse the post-World War I settlement and the restrictions of the Versailles treaty. In 1935, Hitler publicly announced that he was rejecting limits on German military rearmament, and a military buildup that had begun in secret now took place in the open. In 1936, he ordered the military occupation of parts of western Germany declared off-limits to German troops at Versailles, and his action triggered no international response. There were many signs that the

German economy was gearing up to support even more aggressive actions, and Hitler purged the military, the Foreign Ministry, and the Economics Ministry of anyone who questioned his plans to accelerate Germany's preparation for war.

In March 1938, German troops marched into Austria, ostensibly in response to the Austrian people's desire to join the Greater German Reich, also called the Third Reich. (The Nazi state was called the Third Reich because it claimed to be the successor to two earlier regimes, the Holy Roman Empire, dissolved in 1806, and the German Empire, or Deutsches Reich, of 1871 to 1918.) Austrian Jews were now subject to the anti-Semitic measures that had already been put in place in Germany. Germans in the western part of Czechoslovakia, the Sudetenland, which bordered Germany, were the next group that, according to Hitler, sought to be incorporated into the Third Reich. When the Czechoslovakian government threatened to resist Nazi intentions, it received no support from French, British, or Soviet political leaders, who, along with other European powers, feared another war. In October 1938, German troops marched into the Sudetenland. Still facing no apparent opposition, Hitler sent troops into what remained of the Czech state in March 1939. The successful outcome of these high-stakes geopolitical gambles only enhanced Hitler's status and popularity in Germany, contributing to the widespread belief that the Führer could do no wrong.

Hitler's next target was Poland. In August 1939, he struck a bargain with Soviet leader Joseph Stalin. Hitler agreed not to stand in the way of the Soviet Union's expansion of its "sphere of influence" to include eastern Poland and other parts of eastern Europe, in return for Stalin's promise not to oppose German aggression in the rest of Poland. When the agreement became public, world leaders had difficulty believing that the Nazis had signed a nonaggression pact with the nation that was the birthplace of communism. For Stalin's part, he feared that if Germany's invasion of Poland prompted no international reaction, the Soviet Union would be next in line. Hitler justified the Nazi invasion of Poland in September by conjuring up the threat posed to ethnic Germans by their Polish neighbors (Document 34). He hoped that the French and British would join the Soviet Union on the sidelines, doing nothing to stop German aggression, but on September 3, 1939, they declared war on Germany. The Second World War had commenced.

For the rest of 1939 and 1940, no one could halt the Nazi advance. The German army rolled over Poland in weeks, wiping out the Polish army and killing untold numbers of civilians. Many German civilians